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Clyde Kerr Jr.

Clyde Kerr Jr. was born in New Orleans on July 27, 1943. He has taught and mentored numerous young musicians who now carry on the legacy of New Orleans music. Clyde's trumpet can be heard on many jazz and R&B recordings and he speaks fondly of his performances with friends Alvin "Red" Tyler and Kidd Jordan.

Clyde was interviewed in Rome, New York on August 22, 2006 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming in Rome, New York for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. It's a pleasure for me to have Clyde Kerr Jr. with me today.

CK: Thank you.

MR: I'm glad you're up here in the north. I found it interesting that most of you have been commenting on the nice weather.

CK: Oh yeah man. We won't see this type of weather in New Orleans, maybe not until January.

MR: Really.

CK: No we don't have the seasons like a long time ago man. Right now it's very hot and humid and it's raining quite a bit and it's making it crazy and everybody's eyes are on the skies. Hurricane season you know.

MR: Yeah.

CK: So yeah it is a pleasure to be up here man. If anything were going to happen, let it happen now while I'm up here, I'm already evacuated. I don't wish that to happen ever again in my lifetime or anybody else.

MR: You feel like talking about that a little bit?

CK: Sure I'll talk about it.

MR: You were relating how you felt luckier than a lot of people.

CK: Yeah I didn't lose my home like my sister, my daughter, my relatives, my closest friends and everybody that I know, really had twelve, fifteen feet of water and some parts of it were just blown away. My house was elevated. I'm in a section of the city that's supposedly called a "no flood zone" but we did have four or five feet of water, and my neighbor had an apartment unit which is on ground level in the back of my house where I had someone staying there, and I had four feet of water. But that's nothing compared to some people losing everything, their home, furniture, clothes, pictures, mementos, heirlooms and things like that. So I was very lucky man you know. But just because I made out like that it still affected me because of the misery it caused a lot of people who I

love and other folks. I told my daughter, I mean she was a single mom of five kids, and I really told her if I could trade places with you I would do that. So yeah I was lucky man. But at the same time there was a hurricane, we spoke earlier, my son and his wife were stationed in Iraq so I'm thinking about the hurricane and dealing with that at the same time while I was evacuated out of town and I didn't know what conditions were in my home at that time so I had all that on my mind, but luckily my son and his wife are out of Iraq and hopefully they won't have to go back. My house made out okay and little by little it's starting to get back. I'm just waiting to see if New Orleans is going to recover and have some of the flavor and the spiritual things coming back that the people bring, not the government, the city government or the state government. Hopefully it's the people that really makes a difference, that gives it that flavor of New Orleans. I'm waiting to see if that's going to happen.

MR: When you say "the people," New Orleans has always had the most amazing mix of people.

CK: Exactly.

MR: So that's what you're hoping comes back.

CK: Yeah, yeah. From all walks of life you know. If you've ever been to New Orleans and attended a jazz funeral in New Orleans, you know like some of the old time jazz musicians, when they pass, it's always at that time when I attend one of those and I listen to the music, I listen to the musicians come together to play and the singers coming together to sing, and watch the people coming in from all types of walks of life. It's then that I realize why I stayed in New Orleans all my life. That particular thing. It's like with the music, with the musicians who come together to perform at this particular time. Ordinarily some folks might not get along as well because of human relationships or whatever, but when they put their differences aside and come together for the main purpose of just paying homage to this great musician who passed, that's the purity, that's the beauty of it. So if that could come back New Orleans has a good chance of going on from there, not so much to be like it was but to go on and make it even better. But those people have to come back because they're the ones who bring that spirit and that certain thing. It's hard to put into words but you feel it more than you could say what it is, but you feel it. And I remember like one of the last funerals I attended was a great friend of mine, an old guy by the name of Waldron "Frog" Joseph, he was a trombone player that was good friends with my father and my uncle who played trombone back then sometimes I played a lot of gigs with him like brunches. And he had some sons who also are still playing. And being there in the atmosphere of what was going on in that particular church, when I talk about it I get full.

MR: Yeah. There's nothing like it anywhere else I bet.

CK: Right. That's true.

MR: Someone who's not at all familiar with the term "second line" or "second liners," can you describe how that happens and what it's like?

CK: Yeah. When a person passes, when they die, the tradition is the jazz funeral in which the family — we have a procession that goes to the gravesite and there's a brass band that's playing, what we call dirges, which is a slow, very slow song, it's moving, very slow and very solemn-like. It's not the time to play any happy type music because it's a sad occasion. So there's a group of the family members walking in the street behind the hearse or the casket, and there are onlookers who are marching behind them. So after the person is entombed and the family moves on and goes back home then the brass band strikes up a lively type of tune and everybody starts dancing, and it's the people. There's the first line with the family, the second line is the onlookers, so they start dancing and having a good time. Because actually they say you're supposed to rejoice when a person dies, and really cry when a person is born because they have to go through the pain of life you know. So death is like a blessing in some ways, and it makes sense. It makes sense because the person who moved on, they don't have to suffer the things they have to suffer in this particular life you know. They're going on to their reward. So the band strikes up this lively tune and everybody with umbrellas and handkerchiefs are having a good time and they're rejoicing. So that is the second line.

MR: How does the person's particular religion kind of jive with this? Does it make a difference if a person is Episcopalian or if he's Baptist?

CK: No I don't think so. I don't think so. Basically the jazz funerals were sort of designated from musicians so it didn't make any sense. Because you have a service going on in the church and then outside there's another thing going on. So whatever goes on in the church, that's that service or whatever. Outside it has no denomination whatsoever. And so usually outside there are people talking and the brass band around waiting, and you know just waiting for the service inside the church to come out. So sometimes I used to stay in the church if I really was close to the person, I want to be there for the services, whatever, if I knew the person well but not necessarily that I needed to be inside that church. To be outside is another thing to be a part of that because of the conversations that's going on outside with other musicians and people. And I mean actually I would like to be both places. So sometimes you have to make a choice of being in the church or being outside because things are happening both places. So I've been both places. And man it's something that happens that doesn't happen anywhere in the world but New Orleans the way it does. I have experience, like when I evacuated New Orleans I went outside of Atlanta, Georgia, a place called Acworth, Georgia by one of my daughters. From there I went up to New York to do some gigs and I was staying in New Jersey by

my grandson, and I played a gig the following weekend in the East Village at this St. Mark's Center. And the feeling and the love that was in that center at St. Mark's was I felt like I was in the church in New Orleans because it was more a thing of poets and writers who came together to pay homage to New Orleans and Katrina and their words just portrayed how they felt about it. Some were angry about it. Some were beautiful, just peaceful. I performed after Toni Morrison, the great writer. And man she is one of my heroes in life. I love to listen to her speak. I love to listen to her speak just as much as I used to like to listen to John Coltrane or Miles Davis play. What she does with the words is what the other musicians did with the music. So I performed right after she spoke and it was so inspiring and she was very calm and beautifully articulate. There were other writers there who were very angry and militant about things and I understand that's the way they felt. That's the way you play music sometimes, according to how you feel. But the love that was in St. Mark's that particular day, I was thinking, I said wow, this feels like being at home at one of those churches. And it was great. It wasn't the same but it was very close because it was genuine and there was a lot of love right there you know.

MR: Did it affect the way you performed that day do you think?

CK: Oh yes it did. Because what had happened to New Orleans, it was happening to me even though I wasn't there, looking at all the footage of all the people on the bridges and the Superdome and everything, yeah, that had a big effect on me.

MR: How does a young musician prepare to play with a band that's going to play for one of these funeral services?

CK: How do you prepare? Well I guess you prepare if you're born and raised in New Orleans from the time that you come into this life you're preparing yourself. It's not something that all of a sudden happens. It's just a way of life. It's like the breath. It's in the way you walk, the way you speak, it's the whole thing you know. So your whole life is preparation for that you know. It's a thing that happens and from this you go on to the next thing to the next thing to the next thing. As a young musician you witness these particular things and you are aware of everything that happens and from that experience when it happens again you're that much better and it just keeps getting better and better you know. If you really understand what it's all about. It's not a thing about your ego or anything. You have to put all that aside. Because I've witnessed musicians playing inside the church that came together to play for that particular purpose of that day at that service that ordinarily may not get along as well otherwise. But when they come together like that it's the beauty. It's pure. And the music, it has no other meaning than just to serve the purpose of what it's there for. And to me it's one of the biggest purposes of music. Music was given to us as a celebration of life. And in playing in the churches, it is a celebration of life. Death is a celebration of life you know, and it has no, I mean it doesn't matter if you are

rich or poor, black or white or whatever man. It's just pureness. Like stripping you of everything down to your basic human nature. And so when the musicians come and play like that, that's what music is all about you know. We've taken music and done so many things — we created industries, you have this type of music, you have rap, hip hop, jazz, all blah blah and all that stuff and man, the purpose I think that God gave us music is to celebrate life. And when you get sidetracked from that it becomes something else and you defeat the whole purpose. You can make a living in being in the music business, fine. But don't forget about what it's all about.

MR: Uh huh. Don't forget about the music. That's well said. I suspect that you've worn a lot of hats in the music business to make a living you have to prepared to do a lot of different things.

CK: Oh definitely yes. Oh yeah. If you want to work and do — you know I taught school for 42 years. I just retired last week, 42 years.

MR: Wow congratulations.

CK: When I started man, after the first couple of weeks, I said I will never make ten years doing this. So 42 years later here I am just retiring. So I taught. My father was a teacher and my grandfather and my grandmother were teachers. My sister is a teacher and my daughters. One is still a teacher. One taught for three years and she gave it up, she is now a nurse. But playing music, I started out I just wanted to be just strictly a jazz musician but like most New Orleans musicians who wanted to just play jazz you have to play the rock & roll or rhythm & blues or brass bands, so I've done all that. I played in the street, I played in the clubs, I played in the symphony halls, I played Broadway shows. My degree is in music education. So trying to be say a complete musician, knowing how to read music, I was able to do things that curtailed reading music and playing in bands or orchestras or whatever, as well as going on gigs when there's no written music at all. So by being able to do that I was able to do a lot of different things which has helped me in some way to be the type of teacher that I turned out to be, to experience all those different things. That's what I brought to my lessons, classrooms, you know. And I was very fortunate because I grew up in the home where my father was actually a musician and a teacher, and as a kid I can remember that — I was born in 1943 — I can remember as far back as 1947 on Saturdays my father would have workshops in the living room of our home. And we had a small shotgun house, you know, straight, you know the shotgun. So we had to take out all the furniture in the living room, put it in the alleyway, so these 30 to 35 musicians could get in there and play. And man that was a big novelty for me as a kid just watching all those musicians, all those trumpets, saxophones, trombone players, on Saturday. And I was just sitting on the floor and watching everybody pat their feet. But internally I was listening to the music and it's still with me now. You know it's what

I draw from because that's a part of my experiences you know. My mother sang. She wasn't a professional singer but she sang in church, that's how my parents met, she sang in church, he heard her sing and that was like the beginning of me. But my mother had a beautiful, lyrical sound. And it's a funny thing about it, some years later I found out my tone, my sound on my trumpet, sort of has the same quality of her voice. And thinking about that over the years, probably when I was still in her womb that she was singing, I heard that voice. And I remember as a kid when my mother used to speak on the phone I was sitting next to her on the side of the bed and put my ear to her back to hear the vibration. And it all just came together many years after that, that it probably was bringing me back to those days before I was out in the world to hear the vibrations come. And I didn't know what I was doing at the time. The way I came to realize this is in 1974, '75, I played a gig and I taped the gig and the next day I ran it through my stereo system at home. I was home alone, my family was out of town or something, and the music was playing and my trumpet was playing I was off from the room where I was playing. You know sometimes when you get away from something you can see it better, you can hear it better. And I thought I heard my mother say something to me. So I went in the room, I said, "Mom," I was wondering how she got in my house you know, because she lived a little distance, she was living at the time. And she wasn't there. So I went back and then I heard it again. So I focused in on the tape and I ran the tape back and I started listening a little bit more. Sure enough, man, some of the tones on my trumpet has the quality of her voice. She had a voice like a rich alto voice. And she sang, she wasn't a jazz singer like bop, bebop and all this stuff, but she could carry just a beautiful pure melody the same way Ella Fitzgerald would sing a song with the correct diction and the flow of the voice. So all up until that time I was thinking that I got everything I have musically from my father because he was a trumpet player as well. But that made me realize, I said wow man, as long as I play I could hear my mother's voice.

MR: That's a terrific story. I wonder if it might be part of the reason you were attracted to the flugelhorn also? To grab that alto—

CK: Right, oh yeah. In fact before I had a flugelhorn I used to try to get the flugelhorn sound on my trumpet, to get that big rich, full, dark sound. And until today, now when I'm playing if my tone is not right then anything I play I'm not going to be pleased with it. First of all I've got to get my sound right. And then anything I play after that I'll be pleased with it. But if it doesn't sound right I don't care what I play it's not happening you know.

MR: Isn't it amazing how you take a piece of brass and most trumpets are basically the same, you know you can have a little bit different mouthpiece but you listen to the difference in one trumpet player to the next, it's just unbelievable.

CK: Yeah man. I think that has to do with the concept — first of all I think the sound is already there, no matter what you play on, it's in your head. And that's what I try — no matter what, if I'm playing somebody's instrument I'm trying to hear that and that's the way I'm going to hear it. I have some friends of mine, one guy in particular was a saxophone player, he comes from a family of saxophone players. His name is Raul Johnson. His father was Sun Johnson, and he was a great alto player from the Swing Era and had a great sound. He played with my dad. And I used to hear Raul play, no matter what type of mouthpiece, reed or whatever, or horn, he would always sound the same. So it made me to believe that the sound is already here. But it makes it a little easier if you have the right type of instrument man, you know, to get what you're trying to get. But tone is everything. To me the tone of your instrument is just like your voice. We know people by just listening to the sound of their voice, just the way we know musicians from the sound of their tone of their instrument. When you hear a couple of notes you know that's Charlie Parker. You know that's Clifford Brown. You know that's John Coltrane. You know that's Clark Terry. All those great, great musicians man. So the voice is so important because when we play that is our voice.

MR: Did your father and your mother encourage you to a life in the arts? Because I know you were thinking about being a visual artist also?

CK: Right. Well they encouraged me in the way that they presented me the home that I grew up with with all of that. Because my father was a visual artist as well and my uncles were visual artists. So I had all that around me. I was seeing that, I was into music, seeing all the drawings and the paintings and stuff. So it was there. It was just like saying if you want it there it is. You make a choice, do I want to do this. I wasn't forced. I got my first trumpet when I was nine. And in New Orleans with the shotgun house we had those high ceilings and the lights with the long string and wire with a light bulb hanging from the ceiling you know, and you would pull the string. We didn't have the fixtures and the chandeliers and all that stuff. So my ninth birthday I woke up and dangling from the light was my first trumpet. So man it was a novelty for me. I had my trumpet and I was, you know. So after a few weeks it wore off. And I stuck it under the bed and when I went to high school I started playing again. I wasn't forced to do it. My father was teaching me but I felt so dumb, that he was such a great musician and all that, I didn't want to let him know how much I didn't know which was crazy because, you know. But he was trying to teach me and I didn't know — so much I didn't know — but I was young and stuff. So what I did later on I would listen to him practice and playing and when he would leave I'd go and get his books and play what he was playing you know. So all of a sudden boom, here I was I was playing. And on my mother's side of my family I had great musicians who played with Louis Armstrong. I had some — my mother's maiden name

was Baquet which is a French name — B-A-Q-U-E-T — George Baquet was a very famous clarinet player who played in the twenties and the thirties, in fact he was one of the teachers of a great saxophone player and a clarinet player from New Orleans called Sidney Bechet. So my great uncle.

MR: I'll be darned. That was your great uncle.

CK: My great uncle, yeah. And he had brothers, like Theo Baquet, who played clarinet, who left New Orleans in 1919 and came up to New York and was playing with Jimmy Durante back in those days man. That's my great uncle. I never did meet him but you know, that's part of my history man. So like I say I'm rich.

MR: I don't know if I'm all that well informed but it seems like for some reason the family connection in music is so strong in New Orleans.

CK: It is.

MR: More than anywhere else.

CK: It is very strong man, yeah. 'Cause I was telling some of the students today that most everyone in New Orleans' family, there's somebody who plays music. Say for instance like Kidd Jordan, he's here today with the New Orleans Jazz Camp, he has a son who plays flute, a son who plays trumpet, a daughter who plays the violin and another daughter who sings. And his other three kids, they have something to do with music but you know, they don't play. The Jordan Family. And the kids married into the family called the Chatiers family in New Orleans with sixteen brothers and sisters and all of them played. Now in our jazz camp we have the young grandsons of those kids, they're coming up, so it's like the cycle is moving on. Whether they become professional musicians, we don't know, because they're like eight, nine, ten years old. But they're being exposed to it. If they want it, it's there.

MR: Did the musician's union have much to do with the day-to-day music that was going on in New Orleans during your career?

CK: Yeah they had something to do with it, yeah. They had something to do. But I mean there is just so much that they were doing. If you wanted to make some money I mean you had to do what they could provide for you and then do other things too you know. So it was like being non-musicians. Like most gigs I played coming up man, I played with a band that more than half of the band were not in the union, but it was fun, we were making gigs and making money. One time I got busted for playing with the guys and I had to go before the board. But I don't know it was crazy man. I wanted to say well what do you expect man, I've got a family, at the time I had two kids, I have three altogether. I said I need money, I've got to work. And you know teaching school in New Orleans, that's poverty level you know, it's a shame, it's a damn shame, schools. I can say that on tape — you might have to bleep that out. But and then I was having fun because mostly my

comrades I was playing with — I used to do some union gig with the bow tie and all that, and you're playing dinner engagements or stuff like that man. That was cool. That helped pay the bills. It helped me to do what I wanted to do later on in my life and not do the type of gigs that — I don't have to play music right now if I don't want to because, like I say, I'm retired from teaching so I don't have to get out there and bust the pavement trying to do gigs man. And I'm more selective now in what I play because I just don't have to be out there. And it doesn't feed what I need to right now because the scene has changed so much. When I play now I want to really get full enjoyment out of what I do. I don't have to do a gig and me watching my watch, man when is this over with. I hate that man.

MR: Yeah. It seems like the time is standing still.

CK: Like I could spend a week in hell for a three or four hour gig. I want to feel good about playing music. I want to walk away from that feeling fulfilled in some kind of way. That's what I need to feel to feed my creative spirit. I like playing in church, because playing in church these days, I mean you have an audience that you don't have people selling drinks, people are not smoking, people are not talking. In a lot of clubs in New Orleans man there's so much noise in there that it's hard to concentrate. When I was a young musician and I played in places like that it didn't matter because I really was trying to play. I was listening and trying to get things together. I'm still trying to play because I won't ever get to the point where I say I have it all because I know I never will. But I hear the noise now and I hear all the talking. I hear the clatter of glass and drinks, I hear the mixture of the machines making the drinks, so it's like a slap in the face. When you play in the church you have a captive audience you know. And it's a great place to play man. And it's funny because when I was coming up you couldn't play jazz in church, just jazz in the church. But like within the last ten, fifteen years, I remember once I was playing in the church and I was playing a tune, something I wrote, I said wow, man, I'm playing this music in church you know. I said wow. It just hit me all of a sudden. Times have changed you know. And people appreciate it and why not? Because I offer all my playing to the creator who has given me the talent. That's the first thing.

MR: Do you have any of the session work that you've done that sticks in your head as particularly memorable?

CK: Oh quite a few of them man. The one that I did like from the late sixties up to the end of the seventies, even into the eighties. I had a friend of mine who was a saxophone player, he died in '78 of lymphatic cancer. And we did a lot of sessions together in New Orleans. There was another trumpet player, his name was John Longo, who left New Orleans and went to play with the Ellington Orchestra. So it was John Alvin Thomas, the guy who died, myself, that we did a lot of sessions with people like Patti LaBelle and we did one

with Paul McCartney when he was in New Orleans, that album "Venus and Mars," we did things like with the Neville brothers and a group with The Meters, which is a popular funk group. They're still around but they're not all together like they were, the original members you know. But back in the seventies man, they were one of the hot bands. We did a lot of like New Orleans type kind of grooves, "Hey Pocky A-Way" and things like that. So those are precious memories there, mainly because Alvin is gone and John is somewhere else. But I've done a lot with other musicians too that stick in my mind, but those sessions I did, they were like my brothers man, they were special.

MR: I was poking around on the internet and for some reason I saw this thing about Lady Marmalade. You played on that?

CK: Yeah I played on that with Pat LaBelle. I did two albums with her. Yeah. That was the one I was thinking about, yeah.

MR: You just show up and the music's there and you've got to nail it, right?

CK: Right. You've got to read it. That's what I'm saying about being a reading musician, you could react when there's written music or I've done a lot of sessions where there was no music, you had to just do it from here. Or sometimes they gave you the part from the piano and you put it together. And to be able to do it all, man, means that you are able to do more things. Like in New Orleans at the Jazz and Heritage Festival back in the days when I was playing quite a bit, sometimes I'd play in Economy Hall which is the traditional jazz. Sometimes I'd go to the Ray Ban stage and that was the rhythm & blues with Dr. John and Alan Toussaint and people like that and then I'd go to the jazz tent and play my gig, play with Kidd Jordan, play with Ellis Marsalis or whatever, and then go to the funk stage and play with groups, so sometimes I would do all that in one day. And people go well how can you go from one stage to another stage playing in different styles? I say man I think it's just like one thing to me, because everything comes from the breath and when you blow that horn, you know what your surrounding is about so you just make it go like that. So I mean if I'm playing with the Neville Brothers, I'm not going to play the same way I would play when I'm playing in Economy Hall. But it's the same thing you know, it's the same thing. You just make your instrument sound to blend in to the surroundings that you're in. It's just like going through neighborhoods in New Orleans. You know you go through different neighborhoods and you see the culture may change a little bit this and that or whatever, and you react to that. You do it automatically. Sometimes when you hang out with your friends you might speak a little bit different, use a little bit other terminology that you can't put on tape. Or you go in the other surroundings, you react differently. So it's all a reaction to what's going on at the particular time. To me, and that's what jazz is to me, you're reacting in the moment of what is going on and what's supposed to be happening at that particular time.

MR: Is that the hardest part — well let me rephrase — what's the hardest part for you to teach to younger players about improvising or music in general?

CK: The hardest part. Well one of the things that was hard was that a lot of the young musicians were losing their own identity and copying the style and the notes that other musicians were playing in the beginning. So I would tell them I'd say it's great, man, what you're doing, but it's a time where you have to let that go and start trying to get your own voice, your own style. And some of them still to this day still haven't gotten away from copying whoever they were listening to at the particular time to find their own voice and their own style. I mean you have to do that sometimes to get to where you want to get, but you've got to know when to hold 'em and when to fold 'em like. You know? And for me, like I said, I was just so fortunate I had so much experiences, not only just with the music thing but my life in general. Because I don't draw just from my musical experience I draw from my whole life and try to bring it together. And I always talk about the point. The point is the time that you're in right now, the moment. So this right now, we are at this point of our lives, all three of us here. And so from that we are bringing our experience of who we were yesterday and the day before that to this moment. And from that you can react to certain things because you have that history to draw from. And that's what I used to try to teach those kids who didn't know when to let it go and say okay well I got that, okay let me see what I can do with it to make it mine, to make it sound like — if I would given them an idea. Because I never did like to teach cliches or licks as we call them. I would use certain things as a means to getting to other things. You know say okay, I will give you this. Okay now let me see what you're going to do with it. Some of them would take it and develop it and turn it around so much that I wouldn't even recognize it myself which, that's the purpose. Some of them are still playing the things the way I gave it to them. Like I taught Nicholas Payton as a young musician. He is at home in East New Orleans right now. We were still talking and man he's taking, gone, and it's his now. And another great musician as a young trumpet player, Christian Scott, he's out there, he just has a brand new CD out, trumpet player. But a lot of people associate me with just teaching trumpet players but I had trumpets, piano players, bass players, guitar players, you know. And they're all like family. And a lot of them still keep in touch after so many years.

MR: That's terrific. I know your name shows up a lot if you're looking about other musicians and "was a student of" and it has your name a lot.

CK: Yeah. Yeah I was blessed with having been in that particular situation teaching at the arts school in New Orleans. Half of my career has been in like a regular band director capacity which I used to hate because we had to do football games and parades and all this stuff man. I did it but it wasn't my cup of — you know I had good concert bands but

once I started teaching at the art school for the last twenty years or so is like when it all came together for me. But I use all that experience to bring to the situation I was in, whatever I'm in. You know, when I got to the school, the New Orleans Center for the Creative Arts, at first I didn't know what to do as I was trying to teach a certain way and it took me maybe a year or two years to really realize that I have to teach from my own experiences. So once I started doing that it took off man. I have to teach from my life. Because there are a lot of musicians and teachers rather, who are trying to teach certain things and didn't even live the life so they don't even know what it is. You know you've got to be out there, you have to have those experiences because you have to have something to draw from. And there are some of them who are teaching from what they read in a book.

MR: Which there are an awful lot of books now, aren't there?

CK: Oh yeah, a lot of books man. There weren't any books like that when I was coming up on how to — now there are a lot of books but that could serve you well if you know how to use them. But at some point you have to get away from the book. You have to take the knowledge in the book and turn it inside out. Like today, and I've always taught, about printed music. Printed music has the function of being able to play from the top of the music all the way down, no mistakes, understand everything about the rhythm, the phrasing, the dynamics, everything about it. Okay that's one thing. The next thing from printed music, you can take things out of the content and make them your own, just what's written already. And I found myself doing that as a young musician and at the time I didn't know how valuable it was because I used to play out of those exercise books I was talking about. And before I started really trying to improvise I used to play all the exercises straight down you know. And then when I started listening to more jazz, people like Clifford Brown and Miles, I would play something out of the exercise books and I'd get to one little phrase and it would sound like — hey that sounds like something Clifford Brown would use or play because he had that classical background. He played jazz but his jazz were classical solos, the way he approached the trumpet. So I'd find myself taking a measure or phrase and in fifteen, twenty minutes I'm working it in and out trying it inside out and all of a sudden, oh wait a minute, I've got to get back to the book. But later on I'd finally say wow, that was very valuable. Nobody told me to do that because when I went to school man you couldn't really play jazz in the practice rooms. I'm sure that was happening all over the country. I went to Xavier University and the practice rooms when I was trying to play a Thelonious Monk thing on the piano and every time I hit the tritone the nuns would knock on the door, "Mr. Kerr, now, this is for serious music, you can't play that here." I said, "Well sister, I'm serious." You know but it was

like that. You couldn't do that man. But even teaching in the jazz like I wound up doing, I didn't go to school for that but my school was out there, doing it.

MR: Right. And a student is lucky to have someone who's been out there. That's what I think anyway.

CK: Exactly man. You know like the older musicians who were in my living room when I was a kid. As I grew up and got older and started going out there they treated me with the same love that my dad gave to them.

MR: Your father was credited somewhere they called him "the father of New Orleans big band?"

CK: Yeah you can use some of that terminology. Yeah I would give him credit for doing that. Actually he was one of the people who started music education in the schools. Not only big band but he was one of the founders of — there was a book called *Changes on the Chalkboard* by Al Kennedy. *Changes on the Chalkboard* I think it's Shawnee Press if you ever need a good book, and it deals with music education in the Orleans Parish school system. And my father was one of those who was very instrumental in getting it together. Now he graduated from Xavier University with a degree in English and science and that's what he was teaching in the beginning of his career. But he wound up teaching music for most of all his life in the school system. But his approach to music was from the same type of mindset of science teaching you might say. He taught at a school in New Orleans, Booker T. Washington, in 1947. The principal at the school didn't like jazz so he didn't want a band. But he was teaching English and science but he also had the band. So what he would do, man, he would take a Duke Ellington tune and put it in a symphonic type of form and arrangement so he was able to play that and this guy didn't even know the difference man. You know how it was back when jazz was a bad word, you know, the Devil's music and all that kind of stuff you know.

MR: I'll be darned, even in New Orleans, huh?

CK: Oh yeah man. It's just crazy. But my father did a lot with big bands and he loved Duke Ellington, Fletcher Henderson and the Jimmie Lunceford band and he taught himself how to write music and arrange for big bands and some of his music was at my sister's home in a shed that was outside and I had about a third of that in my home but that part of my house was all wiped out by the storm. She lived by the London Avenue Canal and when that water came over it just knocked it out. Not only the music but tapes, photos and albums and all of that stuff man. It's like a life — and his thing was always hand written so it was like a monk in a monastery copying the scripture. He had a beautiful penmanship man. But I have some of his music. I went to Chicago in the first part of April and we played a couple of his — one of his, an original composition and

arrangement with the Chicago Jazz Ensemble with Jon Faddis. And they really loved it. He did some beautiful music man. I was blessed.

MR: Yeah. I have a little piece of music for you to listen to.

[audio interlude]

CK: Yeah. That brings back memories man.

MR: That's a great moment there. I mean everybody's in the moment and they're listening to you and reacting to you.

CK: Yeah, it's funny man, about that particular, that was the title of the album, I forgot the name of the album, it was with Red Tyler.

MR: Red Tyler, yeah.

CK: On the Rounder label. Red Tyler was one of those musicians that was in my living room in the forties. And this particular tune, the guy was from Boston with the Rounder label. And when we first started playing that tune man, my chops was good, I was playing high, I was playing all this, but I didn't know what the producer was looking for so we did about fifteen, sixteen takes, one day, of that particular tune. And then when we came back we did almost that same amount that day. So to me when you keep repeating it, instead of going up, it goes down, a lack of interest and energy. So that particular take, man, it was one of those that, I mean it's okay the way I play and all but I wish he would have taken the first couple of ones, but it wasn't on the record. So the saxophone player, he had picked the one that he liked best. But jazz music wasn't created under the ideal situations. It came out of a lot of diversity and stuff like that. So with all the mistakes — even I remember there was a critic in Boston when they first heard that, they said yeah the trumpet player missed a note or something like that, but he didn't know how many times I played that song and my lips were getting tired. You know you play a brass instrument, man. So but I still love it because it shows my human quality. I'm not perfect you know.

MR: Is it possible to explain to a student what you think about when you're improvising?

CK: Yeah. I try to explain things like that and again I always refer to my art work. Because to me music is, to put it simply, is straight lines, curved lines and dots. Just like looking at a painting. You see some type of straight lines, you see some type of curved lines, and you see the dots. The straight lines refer to the scales, well let's say the curved lines ought to sound like some type scale. The straight lines are the pages. Some music goes this way, music goes up and down, and then you have the dots, I talk about it's from an interval standpoint. So when you look at a picture, like the picture on the wall, you see all that. And when I learned about Miles Davis some years after I was listening to it, he was great artists. And Miles said "I'm not a trumpet player, I'm a visual artist and the trumpet is my brush." I said wow, that's the way I think about it. And once I said I'm on the right track.

So I try to, you know since music is such an abstract thing I try to paint pictures in my teaching and use a lot of analogies to paint some type of picture in the kids' minds so they can see. Now most of them, they can get that. But if I'm teaching a kid with more of a left brain or approach admitted from an intellectual, then I have to use some other kind of approach. Because they're the ones that have to see it written on paper. See I'm more right brain, that's the more creative side, but I take it from here and put it over here. I can do that. Some people can't take it from here and put it over here, it comes out the same way here. So somewhere in between is where you want to bring it all together. Now my father was very disciplined but he was like more of a left brain type of person. He had the discipline to sit down and work things out and get it. So he wasn't really I'd say an improvisationalist so to say because he dealt with form and what 'cha call that, with rules and things like that. That's the way doctors are, a lot of doctors are like that. He went to school, he wanted to be a doctor and he didn't have enough money so he went into English and science and wound up teaching music though. But he was more with left brain and so his approach to music was very disciplined, like Mozart and Beethoven and all those guys who could learn how to write music and didn't even need a piano, you heard it all and you knew the rules and the formulas. That's what I wanted to say. He learned all the rules and formulas and he transcribed a lot of Duke Ellington music and found out how to blend the instruments to get a particular sound that he wanted to do, so he heard that all in his mind, because he had the formula. Like to write for a clarinet when they're playing in the upper register or with a muted trumpet in between, or maybe a baritone saxophone. But the combination of sound and timbres of each instrument, that was something there man that was amazing man.

MR: You couldn't have picked anybody better than Ellington to do that too.

CK: Oh yeah man, because Duke, in Duke's music, the music was telling the story. You could hear it in the music. You know Jimmie Lunceford too. You know there's a thing he did on "Stormy Weather" and in Jimmie Lunceford, you could hear the storm. It's sort of like some of the music of Richard Strauss, he had like programmatic music. You could hear the story in the music. I remember Till Eulenspiegel — you know the story about that — you could hear it even when he goes to the gallows man, it's all in the music. It says something. So you could hear it in the arrangement. I want to learn how to do that through my improvisation spontaneous. Because I didn't have the discipline to sit — I've written big band music charts but I've done a lot of things by head that's in the classroom. I wanted it quick and fast man.

MR: What happens when a student comes to you and — this has happened to me — they ask me about something that I don't use and that I actually don't know that much about. It could be modes or it could be certain kinds of — they ask me, "When do I use an

enharmonic scale" or something. And I don't use them, so I'm sometimes stumped as to what to say to that person.

CK: Well I always tell them to look at the notes that are involved. I mean the notes themselves will give you the answers. And when it comes down initially to how does it sound, because the ear is the final judge of that. And you may go by the rules all the time but I mean a lot of rules have been broken because this sounds a certain way and if it sounds right then it's right. And if that's the way you want to go nobody can dispute that from you, you say well that's what I meant to do, that's the way I wanted to go. You say okay, that's it. It's yours. I try to give them many different ways to approach things but I always say look at the notes that are involved and hear the sound. If it sounds right then it's right. That's it. Because you could get caught up in the rules and regulations so much, and if we did that all the time we would have never had a Louis Armstrong, Charlie Parker and all because they went beyond the rules. I mean Debussy and Ravel and all those guys, they broke the rules of the guys before them and they weren't popular at their particular time because they were using whole tone scales and all the sounds that they were using. And thank God for that. Otherwise everybody would sound the same. You've got to follow your own instincts in other words. Because I really believe education, no matter if you're teaching music, you're teaching science or math, you're trying to teach a person to think and make judgements for themselves. You know once you've done that then you've done your job. I want to give you enough information so when you get out on your own you can make the most logical judgement and decision for yourself, and that's what it's all about. I said this today with the kids. I could show you or give you cliches and all that but like the thing is you can feed a man, but if you teach him how to fish then he can feed himself. So we're trying to teach these youngsters how to think. And to me the overall thing in this country is they don't want education to work because they don't want people to think for themselves. Because once you start thinking you can see all the bull that they're trying to pull on you, you know. You may have a Ph.D. but if you can't really think and see, I mean you can go for anything man. So I don't think, especially with the arts, if you're dealing with the arts and you're really dealing with the arts and you're looking for the truth, you're always looking for the truth, then you're going to see everything. So if we keep people from becoming artists and being able to think and develop their own expression then you can control them in some kind of way. Just because it's in the paper or you see it on T.V. doesn't make it right. You have to see that and try to figure it out for yourself. So I think education in general is to teach a person to think and make the correct decisions for themselves. And especially with jazz being in the moment, and it's going by like that, you have to think quick and you have all these possibilities that can go in that particular moment but this is what I choose at this

particular time. And once it's out you say well there it is. And if you record it there it is. We can't — "well let's do it again." You can do that in the recording studio but if you're playing a live performance you can't. I told a kid that — "wait minute, stop the band, I didn't mean to play that, start again." You're in a night club. You can't do that.

MR: That's right. You have to learn how to deal with what you might have thought — I didn't mean to do that but now I'm going to make it sound like I did.

CK: Right. And that's the thing, to learn how to recover and to react to your mistakes and that's how we learn. We don't learn from doing the same things over and over again. I've learned more from the mistakes I've made that has helped me to become a better teacher. Because I know what you're going through and I know what you're doing because I've done that so I can tell you what you need to do to kind of correct that or whatever. But it's beautiful. I think Miles Davis' style was more out of his weaknesses than his strengths as he developed. I mean in the beginning he would sound like Dizzy Gillespie and when he was hanging around with Charlie Parker and those guys. But sooner or later Miles started developing into these things and then from the forties, fifties, sixties, seventies, eighties, up until the nineties Miles was changing man. He didn't stay the same.

MR: I know. Just seems like when you got into what he was doing he was on to something else.

CK: He was a true artist man. I think he was really a true artist. Not only with music but fashion and visual art. Yeah he was what I call a true artist. And a lot of people didn't like what he was doing toward the end but I loved it and I love it man, I love Miles.

MR: You know I think the average person when they think of New Orleans music they probably typecast it into well yes, I know Dixieland jazz came from there and maybe a little of the Neville Brothers. I don't know, I count myself in this category, that I didn't realize how much — different kinds of things were actually coming out of New Orleans.

CK: Right. And even now as we try to rebuild and regroup, there's been a part of New Orleans music and New Orleans culture for instance that has not been embraced and mainly it's the really avante garde sorry to say. I don't like the word but that's the type of musician Kidd Jordan is. The kind of musician I am too because I can do that as well as play, because it's all the same thing. But unless you sound something like Louis Armstrong or whatever like that man, it's like it doesn't matter. Whatever you do it doesn't matter. With the Improvisational Arts Quintet, that's the group I play with Kidd and Alvin Fielder, we get on the bandstand and sometimes we may not see each other for a year or so and we just get together and start playing. In the beginning of that group we used to play charts and stuff, well not charts but heads of tunes. After you play the head then you're off on your own. But now we don't play that no more, we will just show up

and react among ourselves. And to me that's the whole essence of improvisation. There's no chords, no particular form, you just make it up as you go. And when you can come together and have those moments like that more, you can't beat that you know. But New Orleans hasn't embraced that. To me I think New Orleans is confused or they can't look at the real thing about playing traditional music, creating music or creating music and the tradition that it was created. What I mean by that, if Louis Armstrong wouldn't have taken the initiative to take it further from the guys who he was listening to we would never know about him. So traditional music is playing the way it was or the way, in the beginning, playing in the tradition is to take something that's been done already and bringing it forward.

MR: Do you think there is economic considerations there like tourists aren't going to come to New Orleans or when they come they want to hear the traditional music, what they're expecting?

CK: Not really because there are a lot of tourists that come to New Orleans and have heard things like that and say man, I've been looking for that all day around here. I didn't know that existed in New Orleans you know. It's just that it hasn't been exposed because the people who are trying to make money off you don't think they can make enough. But like I was going to say, at the Jazz Fest when we started playing, twenty-five, thirty years ago, the tent, the jazz tent would be full from the act before us and when we would play in ten minutes that tent would be empty. The only people left would be our family members you know. But over a period of time the tent has grown and people want to hear that. Because it's a new experience. It's the thing that makes them look within their own minds and try to understand what's going on. You keep hearing the same old song, I am so tired of playing some of those — I love the music but I'm tired of playing — I don't want to play some of those same old traditional. I don't want to play "When the Saints Go Marching In." I love it, but there are enough other people playing it. I don't want to do that. And I want to play my thoughts. I want to be honest about it. I want to play how I feel. Some days I feel this way and some days I don't and that's one of the decisions I made like coming out of college and trying to get a career in classical music or jazz and I thought about it and I said okay on a day I might not feel like playing this part I have to play in the orchestra. I'm being honest with myself. So I pursued the jazz because I could play the way I felt. If I didn't feel like playing a high note I didn't have to play that note. I could play according to how I felt at that moment. And I was being true to myself. And I played with a lot of funk bands which I learned a lot. Even though I was playing funk music I was on the bandstand always concentrating on playing my instrument correctly with the correct attack, the correct air, the correct sound. So I wasn't up there that I was

just dancing and having a good time man, I was still learning music and I learned a lot because I was around great musicians too.

MR: Wow. Well you have told me some fascinating things. It's been great.

CK: Oh thank you.

MR: I want to wish you the best of luck with being part of New Orleans coming back, that will be a big thing.

CK: Yeah. Well you know I feel if I'm not a part of it I've done my due. I'm 63 years old and I taught for 42 years and I played music for about 45 years so if there's anything I can do I think I would do it but I taught enough young musicians who are out there that they will be playing for the next 40, 50 years and I had a part to do with that. So if I can do anything I would like New Orleans to open its mind and its ears to other things other than just what it's been doing. And toward like the end of our gigs at the Jazz Fest, we've had full tents, people come looking for us now. But like last year we weren't hired to play because they figured there wasn't any room for that particular type of music. Even my group wasn't hired again. I don't know. The people in charge of it. There's no big deal, that's not my festival. I don't have to be there. But they would say well your music sounds a certain way, in other words, my music is not valuable enough to bring people or the group with Kidd. We are such a different type of band that we don't have a place there. And that's crazy man. Because that's the way New Orleans music came about. It came about by new ideas. If people like Louis Armstrong and Sidney Bechet and all those early musicians and if they didn't take it further from the time they were living you'd have never heard of them. So if anything I would like to see New Orleans just open up and embrace the beauty and the things and the people that are there to make it better than it was before. Because there are some young musicians, one of my students, Nicholas Payton, he is really looking into this free expression, avante garde type of thing. He's done, I mean if you listen to and follow his career and all the records that he has recorded up to this date, he did a sequence of development of music from the beginning, early styles of Louis Armstrong to the modern jazz to the electronic thing and now he's — so I'm glad to see he's doing that. I mean you can be comfortable playing like Louis Armstrong and everybody will praise them and bow down, Lord, you know, but he decided that he needs to be truly himself and needs to do something else. Just like Christian Scott. He's playing the way he wants to play, he's doing what he wants to do, and he's getting a lot of play now. So you have to be comfortable with yourself. You have to feel that. And as other people are doing things, as long as they're comfortable that's what they want to do that's cool. That's for them. It's cool. So I hope New Orleans can come back, I hope it can be better. There's a lot of corruption there, man, it's a lot of jealousy, it's a lot of small mindedness but man, things are going on and even before

Katrina things were going on like in Houston and Atlanta that were flourishing. Even on the Gulf Coast and even with the educational system man. The music thing in New Orleans was suffering even before Katrina. So if we're going to come back we have to take it from the best part of those years and bring it into something else because our kids deserve that. It hurts when you see kids playing like they've never had instructions in their life. And they go to school and they're taking music classes but they're not getting the right information, for whatever reason. So I would love to see New Orleans become what it should be, a beautiful place.

MR: Maybe you ought to get into politics, you've got a lot to say.

CK: No, see with politics, see my nature man, I know myself, I want to be cool, I want to be relaxed and all that so either I'm going to be like this or there's the other side. There's no in between. So if I'm going to deal with some of that other things man, I don't know whether I'd like to. So I've tried that, I already have high blood pressure and take a lot of medication. I don't need to deal with the politics. Someone else can do that.

MR: Okay. Well after all you've done you deserve to take it easy and choose your gigs as you say.

CK: That's right. Exactly. Choose my battles.

MR: Well it's been a real pleasure for me.

CK: Me too man. You know like this whole interview thing is the same approach I do when I play. You don't have an idea what you're going to play. I didn't have a script. You didn't have a script. Or you had some ideas with questioning me. But I walked through the door, I didn't know what was going to happen. I didn't know what key we were going to be talking in. So that's the way I like to react to life, you know just okay, let's see what's going to happen. And when it's all over and done I hope you don't have to do too much editing or whatever. That's the same with my playing music, to have a flow and the voice and when it's all over you can see how it's all connected. As a kid when I used to play on Saturday mornings man I used to love like when I was a kid I had the little plastic cowboys and Indians and the soldiers. And Saturday mornings man, it was beautiful. I'd wake up and I'd fix the covers of my bed to make it look like the mountains, and I always had a great imagination. So I would start my little stories with my toys whatever, and play and from the beginning a story would unfold. I didn't have a script. And then sometimes the Indians would win, sometimes the cowboys would win, sometimes everybody would get wiped out. But when it was all over it was like a story with a beginning, a middle and an ending, just like the Lone Ranger or whatever or some of that stuff back in those days. So that's the way I see my life is like that. And that's the way music is. You have a beginning, a middle and an ending where you state what it is you

develop it and then you recapitulate. So right now my life, I'm in a recapitulation of my life and I hope I have an extended coda.

MR: I do too, a long coda. Lots of repeat signs. Okay.

CK: Yeah man. So I'm just trying to take all my knowledge and bring it to this point right now and make use of all the pain and suffering and happiness too and I can do it. Otherwise it's been for nothing.

MR: All right.

CK: Okay.

MR: Thank you for your time.

CK: Yeah Monk, thank you.